2025-08-26

Dear Maître Nathalie Jacques,

I am writing to request data on the registration of motor vehicles in Quebec for the period 2023-01-01 to 2024-12-31.

Such data has already been made publicly available, on the SAAQ's open data portal, for the calendar years 2011 to 2022 (inclusive) at the following link:

https://www.donneesquebec.ca/recherche/dataset/vehicules-en-circulation

I am requesting individual vehicle-level records in the same general format as the 2011-2022 releases, with one table row per registered vehicle, not aggregated statistics. Please note that additional columns were added from 2017 to 2022, and I wish to obtain the same columns as provided in the 2022 table, in the same digital "csv" file format with the respective years in separate files.

I also request that, for the tables requested here, a column be added with the first three "FSA" digits of the postal code under which each vehicle has been registered. As it is an overtly distinguishing characteristic, vehicle colour may be excluded despite having been disclosed in prior years. This will reduce the need for "small cell suppression" with the addition of partial postal code information.

This request is made pursuant to Quebec's *Act respecting Access to documents held by public bodies and the Protection of personal information*, which grants the public the right to examine and obtain copies of documents held by public bodies, subject to necessary exemptions and redactions. I understand that small cell suppression may be necessary for certain rare vehicle combinations. However, I request that suppression be limited only to combinations where **make + model + FSA** results in fewer than 5 vehicles, without extending suppression to other fields such as model year or engine variant, as these additional characteristics are not typically known to third parties and would unnecessarily reduce data utility. I would further request that where suppression is necessary, it be limited to the exclusion of the postal FSA field only, while retaining all other columns provided in past tables up to 2022. Should privacy considerations require a temporal delay for the most recent data, I would be pleased to receive 2023 data immediately, with 2024 data to follow when deemed appropriate for release.

A full understanding of evolving car ownership patterns in Quebec is a matter of crucial public interest. My aim is to conduct non-profit, non-partisan, academic analysis of changing car registration patterns over time and their geographic distribution within Quebec. I would like to emphasize that delaying disclosure (or over-redaction) of anonymized registration data in the SAAQ's possession will severely undermine its academic and public interest value. I therefore trust you will agree that the combination of partial postal codes (FSA only) with previously published vehicle characteristics poses minimal privacy risk, as FSAs typically encompass thousands of households.

Please advise me of any applicable fees or additional information required to process this request. I appreciate your cooperation and look forward to your response at your earliest convenience.

With best regards,

Rick Hoge, Ph.D.
Associate Professor, Faculty of Medicine
McGill University
[redacted]
tel. [redacted]